

Teaching Statement

Josué Ortega j.ortega@qub.ac.uk

I have nine years of University teaching experience across Essex, Mannheim and Belfast, covering a wide range of undergraduate and postgraduate courses, including introduction to economics, introduction to econometrics, mathematics for economists, intermediate and advanced microeconomics, game theory, and market design. I have experience teaching both large groups of nearly 300 students as well as smaller classes of just a dozen. With regards to pedagogic certifications, I'm a Fellow of the UK Higher Education Academy since 2018. My teaching has been consistently recognised through awards and nominations, including the Queen's Teaching Award and earlier recognition at the University of Glasgow during my time as postgraduate teaching assistant.

In addition to teaching, I provide programme-level leadership. As Programme Director for undergraduate Economics and Economics with Finance in Belfast, I am responsible for curriculum coherence across modules, monitoring student progression and attainment, and ensuring that our programmes provide students with the skills they need to get the jobs, internships, and postgraduate programs they want.

Teaching Philosophy. Two features define my approach to teaching. First, I teach economics by asking students to use formal tools on questions they recognize, and then increasing the level of rigour as their understanding develops. Even in theoretical or mathematical modules, I focus on how the material helps students analyse real economic phenomena, even those that we regularly don't normally associate with economics. Most students will not become academics, so I make it clear why the concepts matter and how they are used outside the classroom. Second, I make an effort to connect students with the profession, because in my experience, often students are not fully aware of all the opportunities available for them upon graduation. I regularly invite external speakers from central banks, government agencies and industry, making an effort to include speakers from under-represented backgrounds. These sessions give students a broader perspective on career options and show minority students that everyone can become a great economist irrespective of their background and circumstances.

I also care deeply about student support. I design my modules to be clear and well-structured, using freely available books and material whenever possible. As a personal rule, I respond quickly to questions, give detailed and fast feedback on midterms and assignments, and ensure that assessments cover the material comprehensively including choices of questions, focusing on the main economic takeaways rather than calculations memorized by hard.

One student summarized my teaching as follows:

"Josue offered strong feedback, genuinely seemed to care about us as students and how we felt. Gave individual feedback on our midterms in less than a week. Josue went out of his way to organise additional guest lectures and was very passionate about his subject. Best lecturer I have encountered in my time at QUB."

I take particular pride in designing lots of questions and examples to be solved during our lectures and tutorials. From personal experience, learning is hard when faced with 2-hours of slides in a large auditorium, so I try to keep students busy solving problems by hand and illustrating not only the existence of solutions, but their computation in a variety of examples. I think this hands-on approach to advanced modules, like game theory and advanced microeconomics, is valued by students, as the next student quote shows.

"I just wanted to say that I really enjoy the module. Last year I didn't like the Micro module that much, so I was worried about this year's one, but surprisingly this module is great. I really like the structure of the module. Also I feel like I'm actually learning something for once, so thanks."

Evidence. A concrete example of my teaching leadership is how I redesigned and improved the *Mathematics for Economics* module at Belfast, a first-year course that had been a major problem in our programs because it had a 35% fail rate and a 43 out of 100 average mark, which was stopping our students from progressing into second year and was causing our programs to be poorly ranked in national tables. I redesigned the module with two-different lectures for students with and without a mathematics background, yet converging to the same assessment. The idea was to let students with weaker backgrounds build their confidence, and teach them in smaller groups so they would feel more comfortable asking questions throughout the lectures. In the academic year 2025/26, the failure rate went from 35% before I took on the module to 4%, with minimal gaps between students with A-levels in mathematics and those without, and without compromising the quality of assessments.

Supervision. I have supervised over 30 undergraduate and masters' dissertation, mainly as external supervisor and examiner at the University of Glasgow and at Peking University HSBC Business School (PHBS). My guiding principle is that a finished dissertation is better than a perfect dissertation, as I am aware that students face tight deadlines to produce a thesis, and that it is common to be overly ambitious about what one can achieve within six months. Thus, I try to help students from the beginning to narrow their research project to a clearly answerable question. I also help them to identify the data they need within a month and make sure they can access it, as well as getting their ethical approval ready if they are interested in conducting lab experiments. I see genuine value in tackling small questions when the students are well aware of what has been done in the literature.

I am also the main supervisor of a PhD student in Belfast, funded by the Department of Economy (we don't have a structured PhD program, so we need to find funding for all students). I also hosted two visiting students from the Indian Statistical Institute. I encourage early-stage researchers to develop joint projects as a bridge toward independent research. I have published with both visiting students from the Indian Statistical Institute and currently have a revise-and-resubmit with my PhD student at the *Journal of Mathematical Economics*.

Conclusion. Ultimately, my aim is to give students both the confidence to engage with economics and the tools to think critically about economic problems. I want students to leave my courses not only able to solve technical problems, but also able to understand why the tools they have learned matter, when they can be applied, and what their limitations are. Whether teaching mathematics, microeconomics, econometrics, or market design, I therefore try to combine analytical rigour with accessibility and a clear connection to the questions that economists and policymakers actually face. Ultimately, I want my students to become independent thinkers: able to reason from first principles, communicate their ideas clearly, and approach unfamiliar economic problems with confidence.